# Level 5 Adult ESL Curriculum · Lesson 2 (Week 2): By the Time We Opened

**Status:** Published. Listening audio, lesson pages, and teacher slides are ready.

**Date:** October 2026

**Audience:** Program coordinators and volunteer teachers

**Companion files:** images/ (12 vocabulary pictures + images/CREDITS_L5_L2.md). Listening audio: L5_L2_listening.mp3 (1:39).

> **Topic:** A neighborhood bakery getting ready to open. Learners say what had already happened before the next thing, put events in order, and write a short project note.

## How this lesson is organized

| Part | What's inside | Who uses it |
|---|---|---|
| **Teacher Plan** | At a glance, the clock, step-by-step boxes, the listening script, the answer key, teacher notes | Volunteer teachers |
| **Student Pages** | Opening Talk, New Words, Listening, Grammar, Talk Time, Homework, Read & Write, Exit Ticket | Learners |
| **Picture Credits** | Picture and license lines | Coordinators |

## What Lesson 2 builds on and what it adds

| Before (review only) | Where | New in Level 5 Lesson 2 |
|---|---|---|
| *already / yet / just* | Level 4 Lesson 3 | *already* now sits before *had*: *we had already painted* |
| *before / after / when* | Level 4 Lesson 13 | *by the time* marks the **later** past |
| Past continuous as background | earlier lessons | *The painter was still working when the inspector knocked.* |
| *I've been working* | Lesson 1 | Opening Talk only. The new point is *had* + past participle for the **earlier** past. |

TEACHER PLAN

# Lesson 2 (Week 2)

By the Time We Opened

At a glance · Clock · Steps · Script and answer key

# How to Use This Plan

**Teach in English.** You do not need to speak the learners' languages. Draw two X's on a line. There is no contrast-tip box. The common mix-up is a row in the mistakes table.

**Instructions:** *Listen. Circle. Number. Write. Work with a partner. Give a reason.*

**Instruction rule: Model it**, **check it** ("Which time is earlier?"), **then go**.

**When a learner is stuck:** show the two X's, give one more English example, point to the grammar box, let a classmate help for a few seconds, then stay in English.

**About four sentences:** the exit ticket is four sentences: an earlier event, a later event, one more event, and why the order mattered.

# Lesson 2 (Week 2): By the Time We Opened

## At a glance

**Objectives: learners can…**

- say what had already happened
- use *by the time* and *when* with two past times
- put four events in order
- write a short project note

**Materials**

- Student Pages for Lesson 2 (print the number you expect + 3 spares)
- Board and markers. Two X's: left = *earlier: had painted*; right = *later: the inspector arrived*
- Four picture cards from the bakery set, one pack per pair (bakery, oven, paint roller, inspector). Shuffle them.
- Listening: L5_L2_listening.mp3 (1:39). Play it two times. No speaker? Read the script aloud with a volunteer.
- **Prep time:** 15 minutes. Draw the line. Shuffle the card packs.

**Key vocabulary (with pictures on the New Words page)**

★ bakery • ★ oven • ★ permit • ★ inspector • ★ paint roller • ★ store sign • ★ ribbon • ★ opening day • ★ counter • ★ display case • awning • poster

## Clock-time plan

*Times are loose. If listening or Talk Time runs long, take the time from Read & Write.*

| Time | Step | Min | Grouping (15 / 7–8) | If running behind |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6:00–6:06 | **Opening Talk + Homework Check** | 6 | Pairs (one group of 3 if odd) / pairs | One card only |
| 6:06–6:12 | **New Words** + a one-minute meaning check | 6 | Whole class, then pairs | Teach the ★ words only |
| 6:12–6:32 | **Listening** (play 1 = Task A; play 2 = Tasks B and C) + "Hear it, say it" | 20 | Individuals, then pairs check | Do Task C together on the board |
| 6:32–6:45 | **Grammar Q&A** + a short pair check | 13 | Whole class, then pairs | Skip the pair check |
| 6:45–7:00 | BREAK | 15 | | |
| 7:00–7:18 | **Talk Time: Two Timelines + Tell the Other Group** | 18 | Pairs, then a second pair / pairs, then one switch | Round 1 only |
| 7:18–7:25 | **Read & Write:** the project update + start the note | 7 | Pairs read; then individual writing | Questions only; the note is homework |
| 7:25–7:30 | **Exit Ticket + Homework** | 5 | Individuals | **Never skip** |

> **Skip order:** (1) the writing task; (2) the grammar pair check; (3) Talk Time round 2. **Never skip** listening, the grammar boxes, the mistakes table, or the exit ticket.

> **5 or fewer:** one group builds one timeline on the table.

## Step by step

### Step 1 · 6:00–6:06 · Opening Talk + Homework Check · 6 min

- **Grouping:** pairs. 15 learners: 7 pairs + 1 group of 3. 7–8: 3–4 pairs. 5 or fewer: pairs, or one group with you.
- **Opening:** one question from last week. A asks. B answers in a short summary. A asks one follow-up. Then switch.
- **Model:** "How long have you been studying English?" If the learner says *I am studying since September*, point to the Lesson 1 fix: *I've been studying since September* or *I've studied since September*.
- **Homework check (last 2 min):** pairs read one sentence from Lesson 1 Homework item 1. You write two corrections on the board. No names.
- **If behind:** one card only.

### Step 2 · 6:06–6:12 · New Words · 6 min

- **Do:** point, say, repeat. ★ = most important.
- **Show the hard words:** the *oven* bakes. It is not a person. The *inspector* visits before opening day. A *permit* is the paper that says the work is allowed. A *paint roller* spreads paint on a wall. The *awning* is a cover over the door, not a cake. The *store sign* and the *poster* are two different things. In our story, the sign went up first.
- **Check the meaning:** "Is the oven a person?" (no, it bakes) • "Who comes before opening day?" (the inspector) • "Is an awning a cover or a cake?" (a cover)
- **Partner game:** A points to two pictures and asks, "Which one comes first in a bakery opening?" B answers with *before*. Switch.
- **If behind:** the ★ words only.

## Step 3 · 6:12–6:32 · Listening + "Hear it, say it" · 20 min

- **Before you listen:** "Priya and Ben work at a new bakery. Ms. Cole, the inspector, visits before opening day. Listen: is the bakery open yet?"
- **Voices:** Priya, Ben, and Ms. Cole. A narrator opens and closes. Audio is recorded (about 1:39). Read the script two times.
- **Play 1 → Task A.** Answer: **b. No. It opens tomorrow.**
- **Play 2 → Tasks B and C.** B is the order of five events. C is *had* or the simple past.
- **"Hear it, say it":** *gonna* and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms. Say the full *had* so the two times stay clear. *We'd already* is easy to miss. In this lesson, say *had*.
- **If behind:** Task C on the board.

## Step 4 · 6:32–6:45 · Grammar Q&A · 13 min

- **Draw two X's.** Label the left one "earlier: had painted" and the right one "later: the inspector arrived."
- **Rule of thumb:** the earlier past uses *had* + past participle. The later past uses the simple past. *By the time* marks the later time.
- **Read the boxes across.** Box 1 is *by the time* and *when*. Box 2 is earlier and later. Box 3 is the past continuous at the later moment. Box 4 is the rule in three lines.
- **Questions and answers:** *Had you finished the sign before the poster went up? → Yes, we had. / No, we hadn't.*
- **Practice, mistakes, then the pair check:** A says a later time (*the inspector arrived*). B says what had already happened. Switch.
- **If behind:** skip the pair check.

## Break · 6:45–7:00 · 15 min

- Leave the two X's on the board.

### Step 5 · 7:00–7:18 · Talk Time · 18 min

- **Round 1, Two Timelines:** each learner gets four picture cards from a bakery opening. They are shuffled. The partner asks, "What had they already done by the time…?" Together they rebuild the order.
- **Round 2, Tell the Other Group:** a new partner retells the story in four sentences. Use *by the time* or *had already*.
- **15 learners:** pairs, then a second pair.
- **7–8 learners:** pairs, then one switch. Listen to the learners who did not do the baseline last week.
- **5 or fewer:** one group builds one timeline on the table.
- **Projects can be invented.** Do not ask learners to describe a move between countries.
- **If behind:** round 1 only.

### Step 6 · 7:18–7:25 · Read & Write · 7 min

- **Read** Priya's project update. Pairs answer the five questions.
- **Write** a 6–8 sentence note about a project you finished (a class, a move inside the city, a team at work). Use *by the time* once and *had already* once. Invented details are fine. This is writing check 1. Start in class. Finish at home. You will write one strength and one fix. Learners keep the note in a folder.
- **If behind:** questions only.

### Step 7 · 7:25–7:30 · Exit Ticket + Homework · 5 min · NEVER SKIP

- **Exit ticket:** *Tell one change, in order.* Four sentences with *by the time* or *had already*, plus a reason the order mattered.
- **Collect and sort** into yes / almost / not yet. Next week, two corrections, no names.
- **Homework:** about 20–25 minutes. Do item 1 together: *By the time the inspector arrived, we had already painted the walls.*

## Listening script

Audio is recorded (about 1:39). Read it with volunteers at a natural, friendly speed. The spoken lines use *going to* and *want to*. *gonna* and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms.

**Narrator:** Lesson two. Priya and Ben work at a new bakery. Opening day is tomorrow. Ms. Cole, the inspector, is here today.

**Ms. Cole:** Good morning. I'm Ms. Cole. Is the bakery open yet?

**Priya:** Not yet. We want to open tomorrow. We are going to cut the ribbon in the morning.

**Ms. Cole:** What had you already finished before I arrived?

**Ben:** By the time you arrived, we had already painted the walls.

**Priya:** When the oven was delivered, Ben had already cleaned the kitchen.

**Ms. Cole:** Had you finished the store sign before the poster went up?

**Ben:** Yes, we had. The sign was first. Then the poster went up.

**Priya:** We had already picked up the permit before we painted.

**Ben:** First I cleaned the kitchen. Second, the oven arrived. Third, we painted. Fourth, the poster went up. You arrived last.

**Ms. Cole:** Was the painter still working when I knocked?

**Priya:** Yes. The painter was still working. The walls are dry now.

**Ms. Cole:** The display case and the awning look ready. You can open tomorrow.

**Ben:** The counter was ready yesterday. Thank you.

**Ms. Cole:** Bring the permit to the door in the morning.

**Ben:** We will. It is already in the folder.

**Priya:** We want to tell the staff tonight. We are going to hang the ribbon in the morning.

**Narrator:** That's the end of the listening.

## Answer key

- *Check the meaning:* 1 no, it bakes. 2 the inspector. 3 a cover.
- *Listening Task A:* **b. No. It opens tomorrow.**
- *Listening Task B:* 1 cleaned the kitchen. 2 the oven arrived. 3 we painted. 4 the poster went up. 5 the inspector.
- *Listening Task C:* 1 had. 2 arrived. 3 had. 4 went. 5 had. 6 was.
- *Grammar Practice A:* 1 had. 2 had. 3 arrived. 4 went. 5 had. 6 was.
- *Grammar Practice B:* 1 arrived. 2 had already painted. 3 opened. 4 was delivered. 5 Yes, we had. 6 was working.
- *Talk Time:* answers will vary. Four events, in order, with *had already* or *by the time*.
- *Homework 1:* 1 By the time the inspector arrived, we had already painted the walls. 2 When the oven was delivered, Ben had already cleaned the kitchen. 3 Yes, we had. 4 The painter was still

working when the inspector knocked. *Homework 2 and 3:* answers will vary. *Homework 4:* 1 I've been working. 2 worked. 3 I've worked. 4 She's been taking.

- *Read & Write:* 1 No. It opens tomorrow. 2 He had cleaned the kitchen. 3 They had painted the walls. 4 The store sign was first. 5 The permit and dry paint.
- *Exit ticket:* answers will vary. *A good answer:* "By the time the inspector arrived, we had already painted the walls. When the oven was delivered, Ben had already cleaned the kitchen. The poster went up after the sign. The order mattered because the inspector needed the permit and dry paint."

## Teacher notes

- **Draw two X's** and leave them up all night. Left: "earlier: had painted." Right: "later: the inspector arrived."
- **Say the full *had*.** *We'd already* is easy to miss, and *have* is a different time. This lesson keeps *had* strong.
- **The *by the time* half is the later event.** *By the time we had opened, the inspector arrived* swaps the times. The fix is *By the time we opened, the inspector had arrived.*
- **Projects can be invented.** Do not ask learners to describe a move between countries. A class, a team at work, or a move inside the city is enough.
- **Writing check 1:** the 6–8 sentence note. Write one strength and one fix. Learners keep it.
- **Reductions:** the script says *going to* and *want to*. People often say *gonna* and *wanna*. Learners only need to recognize the short forms.

STUDENT WORKBOOK

# Lesson 2 (Week 2)

By the Time We Opened

Opening Talk · New Words · Listening · Grammar · Talk Time · Homework · Read & Write · Exit Ticket

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Opening Talk

Name: _____ Date: _____

## Work with a partner. A asks. B answers in a short summary. A asks one follow-up. Then switch.

| | |
|---|---|
| **A:** How long have you been working, or studying English? | **A:** What have you been practicing? |
| **A:** Have you finished any training? | **A:** Give one example from last week. |

*Follow-ups:* **How long? • For or since? • Can you give an example?**

## Homework check

Read one sentence from Lesson 1, Homework item 1, to your partner.

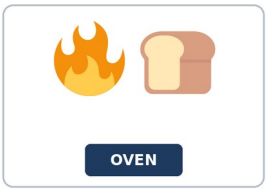
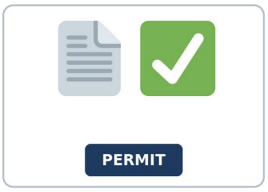
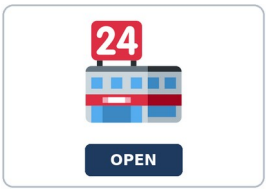
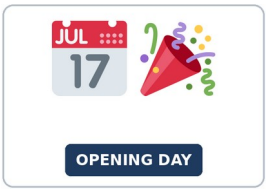
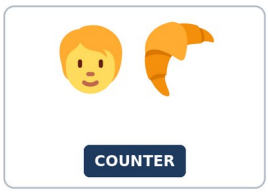
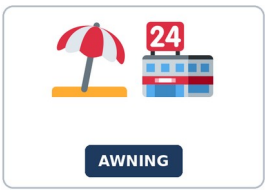
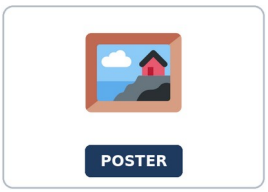
| My partner's name | One *been* or *worked* sentence |
|---|---|
| | |

# Lesson 2 (Week 2): By the Time We Opened

Name: _____ Date: _____

## New Words

**Look. Listen. Repeat.** ★ = most important words.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
|  ★ **bakery** |  ★ **oven** |  ★ **permit** |  ★ **inspector** |
|  ★ **paint roller** |  ★ **store sign** |  ★ **ribbon** |  ★ **opening day** |
|  ★ **counter** |  ★ **display case** |  **awning** |  **poster** |

## Partner game: Which one comes first?

*Example:* A points to the store sign and the poster. "Which one came first?" B says, "The store sign was first." Switch.

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Listening

*Priya and Ben work at a new bakery. Ms. Cole, the inspector, visits before opening day.*

## A. Listen. Is the bakery open yet? Circle.

**a.** Yes. It is open now. **b.** No. It opens tomorrow. **c.** No. It failed the visit.

## B. Listen again. What happened first, second, third, fourth, and last? Circle.

1. First: (**cleaned the kitchen** / **the poster** / **the inspector**)
2. Second: (**the oven arrived** / **opening day** / **the ribbon**)
3. Third: (**we painted** / **we opened** / **we failed**)
4. Fourth: (**the poster went up** / **the oven** / **the permit**)
5. Last: (**the inspector** / **the oven** / **the sign**)

## C. Listen again. Write *had* or the simple past.

1. We _____ already painted the walls.
2. You _____ last.
3. Ben _____ already cleaned the kitchen.
4. The poster _____ up.
5. We _____ already picked up the permit.
6. The oven _____ delivered.

## Hear it, say it

*gonna* and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms. You can say *going to* and *want to*.

Say the full word *had*. *had* and *have* are different. Say each line two times.

1. We want to open tomorrow.
2. We are going to cut the ribbon.
3. We had already painted the walls.

4. By the time the inspector arrived, we had painted.

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Grammar

**Read across. A reads the question. B says the answer.**

## Grammar Box 1: *by the time* and *when*

| QUESTION | ANSWER |
|---|---|
| What had you done **by the time** the inspector arrived? | We **had already painted** the walls. |
| What had Ben done **when** the oven was delivered? | Ben **had already cleaned** the kitchen. |
| **Had** you **finished** the sign before the poster went up? | **Yes, we had.** / **No, we hadn't.** |

## Grammar Box 2: earlier and later

| EARLIER: *had* + past participle | LATER: simple past |
|---|---|
| we had already painted the walls | the inspector arrived |
| Ben had already cleaned the kitchen | the oven was delivered |
| we had finished the sign | the poster went up |

## Grammar Box 3: the later moment's background

| QUESTION | ANSWER |
|---|---|
| What was the painter doing when the inspector knocked? | The painter **was still working**. |

## Grammar Box 4: Which time?

| FORM | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|
| earlier past | *had* + past participle: we had already painted |
| later past | simple past: the inspector arrived |
| *by the time* | marks the later time: By the time the inspector arrived, … |

**Rule of thumb:** the earlier past uses *had* + past participle. The later past uses the simple past. *By the time* marks the later time.

## Questions and answers

**Q: Where does *already* go?**

A: Before *had*'s participle: *we had already painted*. Not *we already painted* for the earlier time.

**Q: Which half of *by the time* is later?**

A: The *by the time* half. *By the time the inspector arrived* is later. *we had painted* is earlier.

**Q: *Yes, we did* or *Yes, we had*?**

A: After *Had you…?*, say *Yes, we had.*

## Practice A: Write *had* or the simple past.

1. By the time the inspector arrived, we _____ already painted the walls.
2. When the oven was delivered, Ben _____ already cleaned the kitchen.
3. The inspector _____ after the painting.
4. The poster _____ up after the sign.
5. Had you finished the sign? Yes, we _____.
6. The painter _____ still working when the inspector knocked.

## Practice B: Circle the correct words.

1. By the time the inspector (**arrived** / **had arrived**), we had already painted.
2. We (**already painted** / **had already painted**) the walls.
3. By the time we (**had opened** / **opened**), the inspector had arrived.
4. When the oven (**was delivered** / **had delivered**), Ben had cleaned the kitchen.
5. Had you finished the sign? (**Yes, we had.** / **Yes, we did.**)
6. The painter (**was working** / **had worked**) when the inspector knocked.

## Common mistakes

| ✕ Don't say | ✓ Say |
|---|---|
| When the inspector arrived, we already painted. | When the inspector arrived, we had already painted. |
| By the time we had opened, the inspector arrived. | By the time we opened, the inspector had arrived. |

## Pair check

A says a later time: *the inspector arrived*. B says what had already happened: *We had already painted the walls.* Then switch.

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Talk Time: Two Timelines

## Round 1. Four picture cards, shuffled. Ask: *What had they already done by the time…?* Rebuild the order.

| Order | What had already happened | By the time… |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | | |
| 2 | | |
| 3 | | |
| 4 | | |

## Round 2. Tell the other group. A new partner retells the story in four sentences. Use *by the time* or *had already*.

| Four sentences |
|---|
| 1. |
| 2. |
| 3. |
| 4. |

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Homework

## Homework (about 20–25 minutes). Bring it next week!

### 1. Write the sentence.

*Example:* the inspector / arrive · we / already / paint the walls → *By the time the inspector arrived, we had already painted the walls.*

1. the inspector / arrive · we / already / paint the walls →

   _____

2. the oven / be delivered · Ben / already / clean the kitchen →

   _____

3. Had you finished the sign before the poster went up? →

   _____

4. the painter / still work · the inspector / knock →

   _____

### 2. Finish your project note from Read & Write. This is writing check 1. Use *by the time* once and *had already* once.

☐ 6–8 sentences. ☐ *by the time* once. ☐ *had already* once. ☐ A reason the order mattered.

### 3. Tell the four-sentence story to a friend or a family member. Ask them which event was earlier.

### 4. Review (Lesson 1). Write *I've been working*, *I've worked*, *worked*, or *She's been taking*.

1. I _____ at the hotel for two years. (still true; stress the activity)
2. I _____ at a bakery in 2022. (finished)
3. I _____ here since 2024. (still true; the other correct form)
4. _____ this class since September. (She / the class)

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Read & Write

## A. Read Priya's note to the staff.

**Project update · Opening day is tomorrow**

Opening day is tomorrow. The bakery is not open yet. This note is the order of the work, so the next shift can see what was already done.

By the time Ms. Cole arrived, we had already painted the walls. When the oven was delivered, Ben had already cleaned the kitchen. We had already picked up the permit before we painted. Had we finished the store sign before the poster went up? Yes, we had. The sign went up first. The poster went up after the sign, and it was already up when the inspector arrived.

The painter was still working when Ms. Cole knocked. He stopped. The walls are dry now. She looked at the permit, the oven, and the clean kitchen. She said we can open tomorrow. She needed the permit and dry paint before she could say yes.

Here is the same order in one list. First, Ben cleaned the kitchen. Second, the oven arrived. Third, we painted the walls. Fourth, the poster went up. Last, the inspector arrived. The ribbon is still on the counter. We are going to hang it in the morning. We want every guest to see it on the door. The display case was ready before her visit, and the awning was already up. The paint roller is in the back room. Please do not leave it on the counter.

If you write about your own project, use *by the time* once and *had already* once. A class, a team at work, or a move inside the city is enough. You may invent the details. Please do not describe a move between countries. This note is practice. It is not a real city permit.

## B. Answer the questions.

1. Is the bakery open yet? _____
2. What had Ben done when the oven was delivered?

   _____
3. What had they done by the time Ms. Cole arrived?

   _____
4. Which went up first? _____

5. What did she need before she said yes?

_____

## C. Write a 6–8 sentence note about a project you finished. Use *by the time* once and *had already* once. Invented details are fine. (Writing check 1.)

*Example: By the time the class show started, we had already set the chairs. When the teacher arrived, I had already printed the sign. The order mattered because guests needed a place to sit. We had already checked the list before the door opened.*

| My note |
| --- |
| |

# Lesson 2 (Week 2) · Exit Ticket

Name: _____ Date: _____

## Tell one change, in order. Four sentences. Then give this page to your teacher.

1. One earlier event (*had already*). 2. The later event (*by the time* or *when*). 3. One more event in order. 4. Why the order mattered.

| My answer |
|---|
| 1. |
| 2. |
| 3. |
| 4. |

| For the teacher | yes | almost | not yet |
|---|---|---|---|
| Four sentences, *had* or *by the time*, a reason | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

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Listening audio: L5_L2_listening.mp3 (1:39). The voices are computer-generated. No recordings of real people. The names and the story are invented.

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